GILLI-DANDA TO CRICKET

A history of traditional striking games, colonial encounter and the making of modern sport

Deep historical research dossier

Origins • Regional names • Rules and technique • Mahabharata traditions • Premchand • Early English cricket • Colonial India • Historical paintings and photographs • Modern cricket

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Evidence policy: this study distinguishes documented history from popular origin claims. It does not present Gilli-Danda as the proven ancestor of cricket. Historical images are identified by collection records; links and rights notes are provided for verification.

Contents and how to read this study

The chapters move from Gilli-Danda's equipment and regional forms to cricket's documentary history, colonial introduction to India, visual records and modern formats. The comparison asks whether there is evidence of direct descent, not merely whether the games look alike.

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A note on dates

The first securely recorded reference to cricket is not the same as the date it was invented. Likewise, the absence of a dated early Gilli-Danda source does not prove the game is recent. Dates for paintings and photographs refer to the image or object, not necessarily the event depicted.

1. The central question: did Gilli-Danda become Cricket?

Gilli-Danda and cricket invite comparison. Both involve a player using a long implement to strike a smaller object, and both create a contest between striking and fielding. In Gilli-Danda, the projectile is a short tapered wooden peg called the gilli; in cricket, it is a ball. The visual resemblance is striking, especially when Gilli-Danda is described as “cricket without a ball.”

Similarity, however, is not proof of descent. To show that one game evolved into another, historians need evidence of transmission: dated descriptions, shared technical vocabulary, documented contact, or a traceable sequence of rule changes. At present, there is no strong primary-source chain demonstrating that English cricket was directly derived from the Indian game Gilli-Danda.

The strongest conclusion is more nuanced. Gilli-Danda is an established traditional South Asian striking game with many regional forms. Cricket developed in England and has a traceable documentary history by the late sixteenth century. Both belong to a broad human family of bat-and-projectile games, and colonial contact later brought cricket into India, where it became deeply localised. Claims of direct ancestry should be presented as hypotheses or popular tradition, not established fact.

2. What is Gilli-Danda?

Gilli-Danda is a traditional outdoor game played with two pieces of wood. The danda is the longer stick, used as a bat; the gilli is shorter and tapered at both ends. A player uses the danda to flick one end of the gilli so that it rises into the air, then strikes it while airborne to send it away. Opponents may try to catch it, stop it, or return it according to local rules.

The equipment is simple and can often be made locally. A short branch can be shaped into a gilli and a longer straight stick can serve as the danda. This low equipment barrier helps explain why the game became associated with open spaces, neighbourhoods and rural play. It can be played without a formal ground, manufactured ball, protective kit or permanent pitch.

There is no single worldwide rulebook for Gilli-Danda. Local groups differ in the number of attempts, how distance is measured, how catches are scored, whether the gilli is struck once or multiple times, and how a player is dismissed. A historical account should therefore identify the regional version rather than pretend that one modern description represents every community.

3. Names across India and neighbouring regions

The game is known by a wide range of names. Commonly recorded forms include Viti-Dandu in Marathi, Danguli in Bengali, Chinni-Dandu in Kannada, Kitti-Pullu in Tamil, Kuttiyum-Kolum in Malayalam, Gooti-Billa in Telugu, Guli-Badi in Odia and Dandi-Biyo in Nepali. Spellings vary because names are transliterated from different scripts and dialects.

Other names are reported across the wider region, including Gulli-Danda in Punjabi and Hindi-speaking areas, Lappa-Duggi in Pashto-speaking contexts, Alak-Doulak in Persian-language descriptions, and Tipcat in English. Similar games are also found in other parts of the world under local names. Similarity across regions does not automatically prove a single point of origin.

Regional names are not merely vocabulary. They may accompany different stick shapes, scoring systems, number of players and local conventions. The Marathi term Viti-Dandu, for example, is part of a living regional vocabulary in Maharashtra. A good research project should record local pronunciation and spelling from speakers, not rely only on lists copied between websites.

4. The Mauryan-origin claim: what is actually known?

Many modern websites and sports organisations repeat the claim that Gilli-Danda is 2,000 or 2,500 years old and dates to the Mauryan Empire. Some describe it as having spread widely under Mauryan rule. These statements are attractive because they give the game a clear ancient pedigree, but the claim is not supported by a securely identified Mauryan inscription, dated illustration, excavated rulebook or contemporary account naming the game.

The absence of a surviving ancient record does not prove that the game did not exist. Simple stick games are easy to make and may be passed orally for generations. Their material remains are unlikely to survive. But historians must distinguish a plausible antiquity from a demonstrable date. “It may be very old” is different from “it is proven to have begun in 500 BCE.”

The most defensible wording is that Gilli-Danda is a long-standing traditional game of the Indian subcontinent, with no firmly established invention date. The Mauryan origin is a popular historical claim that requires better primary evidence. The distinction is important because a careful history can celebrate a tradition without inventing certainty.

5. The Mahabharata and the Gilli-Danda connection

Some modern descriptions connect Gilli-Danda to a Mahabharata verse mentioning the Pandavas and Kauravas playing with a small wooden object or stick. Indian traditional-games resources sometimes interpret the verse as a reference to a game resembling Gilli-Danda. This is an interesting literary association, but it needs close textual examination before it can be treated as proof.

Epic texts have long transmission histories, multiple recensions and layers of commentary. A word translated as a toy, peg, ball or playing object may not describe the exact modern game. Even if the passage describes a stick-based pastime, it does not necessarily specify the two-stick flick-and-strike mechanics, the scoring system or the regional names used today.

The responsible treatment is to include the Mahabharata association as a traditional interpretation, then explain what the passage does and does not establish. It may show that stick-based play or a related pastime was imaginable in epic storytelling. It does not, without further philological evidence, date the complete modern rules of Gilli-Danda to the epic period.

6. Premchand’s story ‘Gilli-Danda’

One of the most valuable literary references to the game is Premchand’s short story “Gilli-Danda.” The story uses a childhood game as a lens through which to examine memory, class, friendship and social hierarchy. It contrasts the apparent equality of childhood play with the inequalities that shape adult life.

Premchand’s story is not an archaeological report or a rulebook. Its value is cultural and social: it records the emotional importance of the game in the world of early twentieth-century North Indian childhood. The game becomes a shared memory through which characters revisit a time when status seemed less decisive.

The story is especially useful for a research chapter on why people played. Gilli-Danda needed little equipment and could be played in ordinary open spaces. It could create a common activity across neighbourhood groups, even while the adult world around the players remained unequal. Literature preserves experiences that official sports histories often overlook.

7. How to play: basic equipment and setup

The basic equipment consists of a danda, a longer straight stick, and a gilli, a short piece of wood tapered at both ends. Dimensions vary. Many descriptions give a danda of roughly two feet and a gilli of a few inches, but these are practical examples rather than a universal standard. Players need an open space where the struck gilli will not hit bystanders, windows or traffic.

A small notch or shallow depression may be used as a resting point for the gilli. The striker places one end of the gilli in the notch and taps or flicks the raised end with the danda. As the gilli rises, the striker swings again to hit it farther away. In some versions the first flick and second strike are separate actions; other local rules allow more complex sequences.

Players divide into a striking side and fielding side, or take turns individually. The fielders try to catch the airborne gilli or return it to the striking point. The striker's score may depend on distance, successful contacts or the number of times the gilli is hit in the air. Since the rules vary, the players should agree on the local scoring method before starting.

> Research caution: identify the local rule version or image catalogue record before generalising. A modern reconstruction is useful for demonstration but is not automatically an ancient or universal form.

8. Gilli-Danda rules and common variations

In one widely described format, the striker gets a limited number of attempts to flick and hit the gilli. If the gilli is caught by a fielder before it touches the ground, the striker is out. If it is not caught, the distance from the striking point to where the gilli lands can be measured using the length of the danda or gilli, and that count becomes the score.

Other versions allow the striker to hit the gilli repeatedly in the air, with additional points for consecutive contacts or for distance. Some use a return throw: a fielder retrieves the gilli and attempts to hit or throw it back toward the base. The striker may be dismissed if the return lands within a defined area or if a fielder completes a required action.

These variations are not errors. They are a normal feature of informal games that are transmitted through play rather than standardised competition. A serious study should describe the version actually observed, including the local name, number of players, dimensions of the sticks, scoring, dismissal and winning condition.

9. Skill, technique and strategy in Gilli-Danda

Gilli-Danda requires timing and hand-eye coordination. The striker must judge the angle at which the gilli will rise, the speed of the first tap and the moment to swing the danda. A clean strike sends the small wooden object away; a mistimed swing may miss completely or send it only a short distance.

Fielders must react quickly to a small, fast-moving object. Catching requires anticipation, positioning and coordination. In versions where a return throw matters, fielders must also judge distance and aim. The game can therefore develop agility and spatial judgement even though it uses minimal equipment.

Strategy depends on the local scoring system. A striker may prioritise a high, difficult-to-catch hit or a low, controlled shot into open space. Fielders may spread out to cover distance or position themselves near likely landing zones. Because rules differ, the strategic priorities differ too.

10. Why Gilli-Danda was accessible

The game's material simplicity is one of its most important social features. Two pieces of wood can be fashioned without specialist manufacturing. The playing area can be a lane, courtyard, field edge or open patch of ground. There is no need for a regulation pitch, expensive ball, gloves, pads, helmet or a large team.

This accessibility helps explain why Gilli-Danda became associated with childhood and informal neighbourhood play. Children could make equipment from available branches and organise a game with friends. Local rules could be negotiated on the spot. The game was adaptable to the space and number of players available.

Accessibility should not be romanticised as evidence that every child had equal access or that the game was played identically everywhere. Local customs, gender expectations, caste and class boundaries, school schedules and the availability of safe open space all shaped who could play. The game's low cost made it possible, but society still shaped participation.

11. Similar stick-and-projectile games around the world

Gilli-Danda is not the only game in which a small stick or object is struck with a larger stick. Related or comparable games have been recorded in Europe and Asia. Tipcat in England, Lippa in Italy, Bilharda in parts of Spain and Portugal, and other local games share some mechanics with the South Asian game, although their equipment and rules can differ.

Such global parallels raise a historical question: did these games spread from one origin, or did similar games emerge independently because sticks and small projectiles are common materials? Both possibilities may apply in different cases. Without a documented route of transmission, similarity alone cannot settle the question.

Comparative history is still valuable. It shows that bat-and-projectile play is a broad human practice, not the property of one nation. A comparison can examine the shape of the projectile, whether it is tossed or flicked, how the striking implement is used, how distance is scored and what role fielders play.

12. Tipcat and the European comparison

Tipcat is a traditional European game in which a small piece of wood is struck so that it jumps into the air and is then hit with a longer stick. The mechanics make it an especially close comparison with Gilli-Danda. English-language descriptions sometimes use “tipcat” as a translation or equivalent for Gilli-Danda.

However, “tipcat” has its own European history and local variants. A shared English label does not establish that the Indian game and the European game were historically identical or that one directly produced the other. The comparison should be treated as a study of related mechanics and possible cultural contacts, not a proven family tree.

The presence of similar games across Europe and Asia makes a direct Gilli-Danda-to-Cricket claim more complicated. Cricket’s early documentary record is English. The question is whether cricket developed from local English bat-and-ball traditions, whether any Indian game influenced it, or whether broad similarities reflect independent development. The current documentary record supports caution.

13. Cricket before it became a formal sport

Cricket’s exact invention is unknown. The International Cricket Council notes the commonly held view that the game may have emerged among children in the Weald, a wooded region of south-east England, during Saxon or Norman times. This is a hypothesis about the game’s early environment, not a dated invention record.

Cricket likely developed from earlier bat-and-ball or club-and-ball activities. Some accounts suggest a relationship to bowls, in which a batter intervenes to prevent a ball reaching a target. The precise path is uncertain. Early games were likely less standardised than modern cricket, with local equipment and rules.

The earliest documentary evidence is much firmer than the origin story. A court record from Guildford, dated 1598, records John Derrick recalling that he and school friends had played “creckett” there about fifty years earlier. This is widely treated as the earliest definite written reference to cricket.

> Research caution: identify the local rule version or image catalogue record before generalising. A modern reconstruction is useful for demonstration but is not automatically an ancient or universal form.

14. The 1598 Guildford reference

The Guildford reference comes from a legal proceeding over land. John Derrick, a coroner, gave evidence that as a boy he and other schoolboys had played “creckett” on the disputed land. The record is dated 15 January 1598 in the modern calendar, although older dating conventions can produce a 1597 date in some accounts.

This evidence is valuable because it is not a later legend about the game’s origin. It is a contemporary legal record in which cricket is mentioned incidentally. The witness’s recollection places the game in the mid-sixteenth century, around 1550, at Guildford in Surrey.

The document does not tell us the rules, number of players, shape of the bat or exact form of the wicket. It proves that a game called cricket was being played in that place by the time of the witness’s childhood. It is an early documentary anchor, not a complete description of early cricket.

15. Cricket as a children’s game and adult recreation

The ICC’s historical overview notes that the first reference to cricket as an adult sport dates to 1611, while a dictionary from the same year defined it as a boys’ game. This suggests a transition from childhood play toward adult participation, although the process was not a single event.

By the seventeenth century, cricket was developing into a village sport. Local matches could involve communities and attract wagers or patronage. Travel limitations kept early competition geographically concentrated, but the game gradually spread beyond its original south-eastern English heartland.

The distinction between children's play and adult sport is important when comparing cricket with Gilli-Danda. Both could be played informally by young people, but cricket developed institutions, written rules, clubs, patrons and eventually professional players. That institutional history helped cricket become a codified sport.

16. Cricket in the seventeenth century

During the seventeenth century, cricket became more visible in English village life. Local experts could be employed as players, and the game began to attract patrons and wagers. The earliest county-named match known to the ICC took place in 1709, showing that cricket had begun to move beyond purely local contests.

Early cricket did not look exactly like the modern game. Bowling was initially delivered along the ground, and bats were shaped more like curved hockey sticks. The wicket and rules also changed. The straight bat became more useful as bowlers began pitching the ball rather than rolling it.

The seventeenth century was therefore a period of transition from folk play toward organised competition. The game's growing popularity created pressure for common rules, more reliable equipment and recognised clubs. These changes gradually made cricket portable as a standardised sport.

17. The first Laws of Cricket, 1744

The first widely recognised written Laws of Cricket were drawn up in 1744. The ICC's historical summary identifies this as a major milestone. Written laws made it easier for teams from different places to agree on the same contest and settle disputes about dismissal, scoring and the dimensions of play.

The laws were amended in 1774. The ICC notes changes including the introduction of leg-before-wicket, a third stump and a maximum bat width. These developments show that the game was still being negotiated and redesigned in response to new tactics and equipment.

Codification distinguishes cricket's institutional history from the more flexible rule traditions of Gilli-Danda. Gilli-Danda's variation is part of its local life; cricket's governing institutions increasingly sought uniformity so that matches could be compared across places and seasons.

18. Hambledon, MCC and Lord's

The Hambledon Club in Hampshire became a focal point for cricket in the late eighteenth century. The ICC describes it as the game's centre for roughly thirty years before the formation of the Marylebone Cricket Club and the opening of Lord's Old Ground in 1787.

The Marylebone Cricket Club became the custodian of the Laws of Cricket. This gave the game an institutional centre and helped stabilise rules. The club's influence grew as cricket spread through Britain and later across the empire.

Clubs and grounds mattered because they created continuity. They provided places to play, membership structures, records, equipment standards and social networks. Cricket's later global spread depended not only on the bat and ball but also on these institutions.

19. Women's cricket in early England

The ICC records the first known women's cricket match in 1745 in Surrey. This is a significant milestone because it shows that cricket was not exclusively a male activity even in the eighteenth century. Women's cricket has a long history, although it often received less institutional recognition and coverage.

Historical paintings and reports can reveal how women's participation was represented. Some depictions are satirical or caricatured, while others record actual matches. The image titled "Rural Sports or a Cricket Match Extraordinary" by Thomas Rowlandson (1811), held by the National Gallery of Art, is a notable example of a humorous visual treatment of cricket.

Women's cricket developed through clubs, touring teams and eventually international competition. A complete history must not treat women's participation as a recent addition. It should instead examine how opportunities, resources, media attention and governing structures changed over time.

20. Cricket spreads through the British Empire

Cricket spread internationally through British colonial and commercial networks. The ICC notes that it reached North America through English colonies in the seventeenth century, the West Indies through colonists, India through East India Company mariners, Australia around the beginning of colonisation in 1788, and New Zealand and South Africa in the early nineteenth century.

Imperial expansion created routes for soldiers, sailors, administrators, merchants and settlers to carry the game. Cricket was often presented as a marker of British identity and social discipline. Yet local communities did not simply receive the game passively; they adapted it, formed teams and made it their own.

The spread of cricket was therefore both a colonial history and a history of local agency. The game could represent imperial hierarchy, but it could also become a platform through which colonised people challenged social barriers and built new forms of public identity.

21. Cricket arrives in India

The Board of Control for Cricket in India identifies 1751 as the first recorded cricket match in India, played between British Army and civilian or settler groups. The date is an important early milestone in the documented history of cricket on the subcontinent.

Cricket was introduced by British East India Company personnel, soldiers, sailors and settlers. Early matches were largely played within European communities. Indians initially watched these contests, but local participation grew over time, including among soldiers and urban groups.

The BCCI history page identifies the Calcutta Cricket Club, established in 1792, as a major milestone. It describes the club as the second-oldest cricket club in the world after MCC. These dates help trace cricket's institutional development in colonial India.

> Research caution: identify the local rule version or image catalogue record before generalising. A modern reconstruction is useful for demonstration but is not automatically an ancient or universal form.

22. Indian participation and the sepoys

The spread of cricket in India was not confined to British officers. The BCCI notes reports that Indian soldiers, including sepoys, took up the game and sometimes played with enthusiasm. Some accounts describe Indian soldiers as energetic cricketers and record matches between Indian and European military personnel.

Such participation complicates a simple story of cricket as a game imposed from above. Indian players learned the sport, developed skill and entered spaces that colonial authorities had initially controlled. Participation could be shaped by military hierarchy, but it also offered opportunities for recognition and competition.

Cricket's adoption by Indian communities gradually transformed its meaning. A sport associated with British identity became a vehicle for Indian social life, public prestige and eventually national representation. This process took place over generations, not in a single moment.

23. The Parsis and early Indian cricket

The Parsi community of Bombay played a major role in the early development of Indian cricket. Parsi merchants and reformers encountered the game in the colonial city and organised clubs. The Oriental Cricket Club, founded in the 1840s, is commonly cited as an early Indian cricket club, although the precise chronology of early clubs can be complicated by short-lived organisations and changing names.

The Parsis' adoption of cricket was both recreational and social. It allowed a community to engage with a prestigious colonial institution while building its own clubs and public identity. Parsi teams later toured England, demonstrating that Indian players could compete in the heartland of the sport.

The story of Parsi cricket is important because it shows local appropriation rather than passive imitation. Indian communities used cricket to build institutions, cultivate public reputation and negotiate their place in colonial society.

24. The Bombay Quadrangular and community cricket

In late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Bombay, cricket competitions developed around community-based teams. The Bombay Quadrangular grew from contests involving Europeans and Parsis, later expanding to include Hindu and Muslim teams. The competition reflected the city's social organisation and the role of community identity in public sport.

These tournaments could create intense rivalry and large audiences. They also reflected the limits of colonial and communal structures: teams were organised around social categories rather than simply neighbourhoods or sporting ability. The competition is a valuable lens for studying both the popularity and the politics of cricket in urban India.

Over time, criticism grew of communal selection and the social divisions embedded in the tournament. The Quadrangular was eventually replaced by other formats. Its history shows how cricket could both unite spectators through shared excitement and reproduce the divisions of the society in which it was played.

25. Cricket, nationalism and public identity

By the early twentieth century, cricket had become more than a colonial pastime in India. Indian teams and players used the game to demonstrate skill, organisation and collective pride. Touring sides and public matches created opportunities for Indian audiences to see local players compete against British teams.

Cricket's symbolism was complex. It was associated with British institutions and rules, yet Indian success could challenge colonial assumptions about racial and cultural superiority. Players could use a sport introduced by the empire to claim recognition within and beyond imperial society.

After independence in 1947, cricket increasingly became part of national culture. The Indian team's achievements, domestic competitions and later World Cup victories helped turn the sport into a shared public spectacle. The story is not a simple conversion from colonial sport to national sport; it is a long process of appropriation and reinvention.

26. Cricket equipment: from curved bat to modern bat

Early cricket bats were shaped more like curved sticks, reflecting the fact that bowlers initially rolled the ball along the ground. As bowling changed to pitching after about 1760, a straighter bat became more useful. The ICC identifies this change as a major technical turning point.

Modern cricket bats are made from willow, traditionally English willow or Kashmir willow, with a flat striking face and a handle designed for grip and control. The ball has a cork core and tightly wound layers covered by leather. Stumps and bails form the wicket, while protective equipment has become increasingly important as bowling speeds rose.

Equipment changes altered tactics. A straight bat made defensive and driving strokes more effective; improved protective gear allowed batters to face faster bowling; lighter and stronger materials changed the balance of power. Cricket's evolution is partly a history of materials science and manufacturing.

27. The cricket ball and the development of bowling

Early cricket involved underarm or rolled deliveries. As bowlers began pitching the ball, the batter needed a different technique and the bat shape changed. Over time, bowling developed into a sophisticated discipline involving line, length, swing, seam movement, spin and changes of pace.

The ball's construction affects its behaviour. The seam can influence movement through the air or off the pitch, while wear and polishing create different conditions for bowlers. Rules governing the ball, pitch and delivery action have been revised as the game evolved.

Bowling innovation has repeatedly forced changes in batting technique and regulation. Cricket is therefore a contest not only between two teams but between evolving technologies and tactics. The same dynamic—players adapting to new methods—appears in the informal rule changes of traditional games, though cricket's institutional record is much more extensive.

28. The evolution of cricket formats

Cricket developed from local matches into longer multi-day contests, then into limited-overs formats and Twenty20. Test cricket became the traditional international form, with matches lasting up to five days. One-day international cricket introduced a fixed number of overs per side, making matches more predictable in length.

Twenty20 cricket, introduced at professional level in the early twenty-first century, compressed the game into a short evening format. It encouraged aggressive batting, specialist roles, new fielding strategies and commercial entertainment. Franchise leagues expanded the sport's audience and player economy.

Each format changed how audiences experienced cricket. Test matches reward endurance and tactical adjustment over time; one-day cricket balances accumulation and acceleration; T20 foregrounds rapid scoring and high-impact moments. The game's core laws remain recognisable while the experience changes dramatically.

29. Cricket's global governance and international competition

The formation of international cricket structures helped standardise competition across countries. The Imperial Cricket Conference was established in 1909 by England, Australia and South Africa; it later became the International Cricket Council. Membership expanded as more nations gained Test status and international recognition.

International cricket became a stage for national identity. Tours, bilateral series and world tournaments allowed countries to compete in front of mass audiences. The game's global governance also had to address scheduling, player eligibility, umpiring standards, anti-corruption, safety and the commercial rights of competitions.

The international game remains uneven in resources and visibility. A few countries command large audiences and revenues, while associate nations work to expand infrastructure and recognition. The history of cricket is therefore not simply a story of universal spread; it is also a story of unequal development and ongoing debates about access.

30. Cricket imagery: Benjamin West's The Cricketers, 1763

Benjamin West's painting The Cricketers, dated 1763, is one of the important early works depicting cricket as a fashionable activity. The National Portrait Gallery record identifies the sitters as Ralph Izard and friends and describes the work as an oil painting on canvas. The painting captures cricket among educated and wealthy young men.

The UK government's 2022 notice about the painting's export bar described it as showing the evolution of cricket from a rustic pastime toward a sport adopted by the aristocracy in the eighteenth century. It is valuable because it places cricket within the social world of elite leisure.

Use the painting as evidence of how cricket was represented in 1763, not as the earliest image of cricket ever made. The painting's subject and date are well documented, but the game itself had already been played for generations. Its value lies in showing cricket's changing social status.

> Research caution: identify the local rule version or image catalogue record before generalising. A modern reconstruction is useful for demonstration but is not automatically an ancient or universal form.

31. Cricket imagery: Rowlandson's 1811 satire

Thomas Rowlandson's Rural Sports or a Cricket Match Extraordinary, dated 1811 and held by the National Gallery of Art, depicts a cricket match in an exaggerated comic style. The scene includes spectators and a playful, chaotic representation of sporting activity.

Satirical images can reveal contemporary attitudes as much as the mechanics of play. Rowlandson's work can be used to discuss the public culture surrounding cricket, including spectatorship, gender, fashion and the humour attached to sport. It should not be treated as a literal record of a standard match.

The National Gallery of Art identifies the image as public domain under its open-access policy. It is a useful example of a historical cricket image that may be suitable for reproduction, subject to the institution's current terms.

32. Cricket in India: the 1859 Calcutta Cricket Club photograph

The National Army Museum holds a photograph titled Members of the Calcutta Cricket Club, 1859. The collection record identifies it as a photograph made in India in 1859 and notes the role of cricket in colonial military and social life.

The image is important because it is an early photographic record connected to organised cricket in India. It shows the club world that helped establish the sport in colonial cities. The museum's contextual note also explains that Indians increasingly took up the game during the nineteenth century.

The photograph should be captioned with its exact title, date and holding institution. It is not an image of the first match in India, nor does it represent all cricket players. It is a specific visual record of a club community.

> Research caution: identify the local rule version or image catalogue record before generalising. A modern reconstruction is useful for demonstration but is not automatically an ancient or universal form.

33. Cricket in India: Peshawar, circa 1896

The National Army Museum also holds a photograph titled A cricket match, Peshawar, 1896 (circa). The catalogue describes it as a photograph from the North-West Frontier region and places it in an album compiled by an officer of the Indian Army.

This image is useful for studying the spread of cricket beyond the major presidency cities. It also shows how military networks helped carry the game into different parts of the subcontinent. The museum's note describes the increasing participation of Indian soldiers and the wider popularity of cricket by the late nineteenth century.

Because the image is catalogued as circa 1896, the date should remain approximate. A careful historical caption preserves that uncertainty instead of converting it into an exact year.

34. Cricket's earliest images in Australia

The State Library of New South Wales describes a series of watercolours of Hyde Park painted in 1842 by John Rae as the earliest known images of cricket in Australia. Thomas Lewis painted a match in 1843, probably involving a local team and a British regiment stationed in Sydney.

The same archive notes S. T. Gill's lithograph of the 1857 intercolonial match between New South Wales and Victoria, and an image of the 1862 match involving the first English team to tour Australia. A photograph of the 1862 match is described as one of the earliest photographs of a cricket game taken in Australia.

These images show how cricket's visual history travelled with the game. Watercolours, lithographs and photographs each preserve different aspects of play and spectatorship. They also document cricket's role in colonial societies beyond India and England.

> Research caution: identify the local rule version or image catalogue record before generalising. A modern reconstruction is useful for demonstration but is not automatically an ancient or universal form.

35. Cricket and the rise of mass spectatorship

As cricket became more organised, it attracted larger crowds and more extensive press coverage. Grounds became civic landmarks, while newspapers reported scores, players and controversies. Spectatorship turned cricket into a public ritual, especially in cities where clubs and transport made regular attendance possible.

Mass media transformed the relationship between players and audiences. Radio brought live commentary to people who could not attend; television made technique and drama visible; digital platforms created real-time statistics, highlights and global fan communities.

In India, cricket's mass audience became especially powerful after independence and expanded with television, sponsorship and professional leagues. The sport's popularity is now linked to national identity, celebrity culture, advertising and entertainment industries as well as athletic competition.

36. Gilli-Danda and cricket: a technical comparison

Both games use a striking implement and a moving object, but their mechanics differ. Gilli-Danda begins with a small tapered peg that is flicked into the air and then struck. Cricket begins with a bowler delivering a ball toward a batter who defends or attacks a wicket. In Gilli-Danda, distance and catches may determine scoring; in cricket, runs, wickets, overs and boundaries structure the contest.

The fielding roles are also different. Gilli-Danda can be played with flexible numbers and local fielding conventions. Cricket has eleven players per side in its standard formal version, specialised positions and codified dismissals. Cricket's ball can bounce, swing and seam; the wooden gilli has different flight characteristics and is often struck from a stationary base.

The comparison is useful because it reveals a shared family resemblance without erasing distinct histories. A game can resemble another in one mechanic while differing in the structure that makes it a sport. The existence of a striking stick in both does not establish direct descent.

37. Could Gilli-Danda have influenced Cricket?

It is possible that informal stick games contributed to the wider culture of bat-and-ball play in different societies. But a specific claim that Gilli-Danda directly produced cricket would require evidence that the game or its rules travelled from South Asia to England before the earliest cricket references, or that English players adopted a recognisably Indian form.

The known documentary history of cricket points to south-east England by the sixteenth century. The history of Gilli-Danda is much harder to date because it was an informal folk game with limited written documentation. This imbalance makes it difficult to establish a direction of influence.

Popular Indian sports writing sometimes calls Gilli-Danda the ancestor of cricket and baseball. Such claims should be attributed to the source making them and clearly labelled as a theory. The more cautious conclusion is that the two games share mechanics and belong to the broader history of striking games, while direct ancestry remains unproven.

> Research caution: identify the local rule version or image catalogue record before generalising. A modern reconstruction is useful for demonstration but is not automatically an ancient or universal form.

38. Why cricket became codified and Gilli-Danda remained local

Cricket developed clubs, patrons, professional players, written laws, dedicated grounds and national governing bodies. These institutions made it possible to organise matches between distant teams, preserve records and compare performances. Commercial interest and public prestige reinforced the process.

Gilli-Danda largely remained an informal game transmitted through family, neighbourhood and community play. Its rules could change with local preference, and it did not develop a comparable global institutional structure. This does not mean it lacked skill or cultural value; it means its social organisation followed a different path.

The difference also reflects power and resources. Colonial institutions, urban clubs, print media and later broadcasting helped cricket expand. Traditional games often received less institutional investment and were more vulnerable to changes in land use, schooling, urbanisation and the availability of open spaces.

39. The modern revival of traditional games

In recent decades, educators, cultural organisations and traditional-sports groups have promoted games such as Gilli-Danda as part of intangible cultural heritage. Demonstrations, festivals and school programmes can preserve knowledge of equipment and rules that might otherwise be lost.

Revival raises practical questions. Should organisers standardise rules to create tournaments, or preserve local variations? Should equipment dimensions be fixed for safety and fairness? How can children learn the game in dense urban settings where open space is limited? These decisions shape what version of the tradition survives.

A strong preservation programme records local knowledge before standardising it. It can document multiple regional rule sets, oral histories, names, stick-making techniques and memories from older players. Standardised competition can then be presented as one modern format rather than the only authentic version.

40. Safety and responsible play

Gilli-Danda involves a hard wooden object moving quickly through the air. Players should use a clear open area away from roads, windows, animals and spectators. Fielders should stand at a safe distance and agree on a direction of play. A player should never swing the danda when another person is within striking range.

Modern cricket also involves high-speed projectiles and requires safety equipment, particularly for batters facing fast bowling. Helmets, pads, gloves, abdominal guards and protective rules developed as the game became faster and more competitive. The contrast reflects different equipment and levels of formalisation.

Safety should be included in any contemporary revival of Gilli-Danda. The game's low cost is an advantage, but low-cost equipment still requires clear boundaries, safe distances and adult supervision when children play.

41. Timeline: Gilli-Danda and related games

Ancient period: claims of Mauryan-era Gilli-Danda circulate in modern accounts, but no securely identified contemporary source establishes the exact game and rules. Epic references to stick-based play are sometimes interpreted as related, but require philological caution. Medieval and early modern periods: informal stick-and-projectile games likely existed in multiple regions, but their documentation is fragmentary.

Nineteenth century: colonial ethnography, travel writing and local-language literature increasingly record games and childhood recreation, although the evidence is uneven. Early twentieth century: Premchand's short story "Gilli-Danda" provides a notable literary treatment of the game and its social meanings.

Modern period: traditional-games organisations, educational projects and cultural initiatives document regional names and rules. The game continues in local communities and is promoted through revival efforts. No single date can currently be treated as its definitive invention year.

42. Timeline: Cricket

c. 1550: the Guildford witness later recalled playing cricket as a boy around this period. 1598: the Guildford court record provides the earliest definite written reference. 1611: the first known adult-sport reference and a dictionary definition as a boys' game are noted in cricket histories.

Seventeenth century: village cricket develops and adult participation expands. 1709: the earliest known match using county names is recorded. 1744: first written Laws of Cricket. 1745: first known women's match in Surrey. c. 1760: pitched bowling replaces rolling along the ground, encouraging the straight bat.

1774: laws are amended, including LBW and wicket changes. 1787: MCC is founded and Lord's Old Ground opens. 1751: first recorded cricket match in India, according to BCCI. 1792: Calcutta Cricket Club is established. 1891: not a cricket date but a useful comparison point for the standardisation of other traditional games; cricket's modern formats develop later.

43. Cricket's colonial contradictions

Cricket was used by British administrators and commentators as a symbol of discipline, fair play and imperial culture. The game was sometimes presented as a means of teaching colonised people British values. Such rhetoric was part of the wider colonial project and should not be repeated uncritically.

At the same time, Indian players and communities made cricket their own. They formed clubs, challenged exclusion, built public followings and used sporting success to assert capability and status. The game could become a site of negotiation and resistance as well as a colonial institution.

The National Army Museum's historical notes on early cricket in India quote colonial commentary that explicitly links cricket to the history of British colonisation. That material is valuable precisely because it reveals the ideology surrounding the game. It should be read critically alongside Indian accounts and the achievements of Indian players.

44. The transformation from imperial pastime to Indian mass sport

Cricket's Indian transformation took place through schools, clubs, princely patronage, community organisations, military teams, journalism and public competitions. Indian players became skilled participants and spectators developed their own loyalties. The game's meaning changed as it moved beyond the European enclaves where it had first been organised.

After independence, the national team became a powerful symbol of the new country. International victories and prominent players helped turn cricket into a shared national spectacle. The 1983 Cricket World Cup victory is often treated as a watershed in the sport's popular culture, while later television and professional leagues expanded its commercial reach.

Cricket's Indian identity is not a contradiction of its English documentary origins. Games are transformed by the communities that play them. Cricket in India now has its own heroes, institutions, rivalries, styles and social meanings.

45. What historical pictures can and cannot prove

A painting can reveal how a game was imagined, who was represented playing and what social status the activity carried. A photograph can record a particular team, ground or match with greater documentary precision, but its date and caption still need verification. An engraving may reproduce an earlier painting and therefore have a different publication date from the scene it depicts.

Images should be catalogued with the holding institution, artist or photographer, date, medium, accession number and rights information. If an image depicts an earlier event, state both dates clearly: for example, "a nineteenth-century illustration of an eighteenth-century match."

The oldest known surviving image is not necessarily the oldest image ever made. It is the earliest currently identified in the collections and scholarship consulted. This distinction is essential when writing about "oldest pictures" of either Gilli-Danda or cricket.

46. The oldest pictures of Gilli-Danda: limits of the archive

Compared with cricket, Gilli-Danda has a much thinner historical image archive. It was often played informally in streets, fields and courtyards, using temporary or locally made equipment. Such play was less likely to be commissioned as a painting or photographed by colonial studios than elite sport or organised cricket matches.

Modern educational and traditional-games websites publish photographs and diagrams of Gilli-Danda, but a photograph of a contemporary demonstration is not evidence of the game's appearance centuries ago. The date and provenance of every purported historical image should be checked before calling it the oldest.

Where an early image cannot be verified, the honest approach is to show a modern documented demonstration and label it clearly, then place it beside historical literary references and comparative images of related stick games. It is better to acknowledge an archival gap than to invent an ancient painting.

> Research caution: identify the local rule version or image catalogue record before generalising. A modern reconstruction is useful for demonstration but is not automatically an ancient or universal form.

47. A research guide to the most useful cricket images

Benjamin West's The Cricketers (1763), held in the Smithsonian's National Portrait Gallery record, is a key early painting of cricket among elite young men. The UK government's 2022 export-bar notice explains its significance in showing the sport's changing social status in the eighteenth century.

Thomas Rowlandson's Rural Sports or a Cricket Match Extraordinary (1811), in the National Gallery of Art, offers a satirical view of cricket and spectatorship. The Government Art Collection's engraving The Cricket Match between Sussex and Kent, at Brighton was published in 1849 and reproduces an earlier painting exhibited in 1846.

For India, the National Army Museum's Members of the Calcutta Cricket Club, 1859 and A cricket match, Peshawar, 1896 (circa) are valuable photographic records. The State Library of New South Wales provides early Australian images, including John Rae's 1842 watercolours and a photograph of the 1862 match.

48. A comparative study: Gilli-Danda, Tipcat and Cricket

Gilli-Danda and Tipcat share a distinctive action: a short piece is made to leap into the air and then struck with a longer stick. Cricket differs because the ball is delivered by a bowler and the batter's main task is to defend a wicket or score runs. The comparison therefore belongs to a broad family of striking games, not necessarily a single line of descent.

Other bat-and-ball games such as rounders, stoolball and baseball have their own documented histories and rule structures. They may share equipment concepts without sharing a direct ancestor. The development of sport often involves borrowing, parallel invention and local adaptation.

A comparative table should focus on mechanics, equipment, team size, scoring, dismissal, field shape and institutional history. This makes it possible to identify genuine similarities while avoiding a simplistic claim that all bat games are versions of one ancient sport.

49. Glossary of key terms

Gilli: the short tapered wooden peg used in Gilli-Danda. Danda: the longer stick used to flick and strike the gilli. Viti-Dandu: a Marathi name for the game. Danguli: a Bengali name. Dandi-Biyo: a Nepali name. Tipcat: an English-language name for a related European game.

Wicket: the three stumps and two bails defended by the batter in cricket. Bowler: the player who delivers the ball. Batter: the player who attempts to score runs and protect the wicket. Fielder: a player who attempts to stop the ball and dismiss the batter. Over: a set of six legal deliveries in modern standard cricket.

Codification: the process of writing and standardising rules. Provenance: the documented history of an object's ownership and movement. Primary source: evidence created in the period being studied, such as a court record, photograph or contemporary account. Retrospective tradition: a later story about an earlier event that must be evaluated against contemporary evidence.

50. Conclusion: two games, connected by resemblance and history

Gilli-Danda is a traditional South Asian game whose strength lies in simplicity, regional variety and social memory. Its equipment can be made from two pieces of wood, and its rules are transmitted through local play. It appears in modern cultural writing, literature and traditional-games initiatives, but its exact invention date remains unknown. Claims of a Mauryan origin or direct descent from it to cricket need stronger primary evidence.

Cricket has a much clearer documentary chronology. The 1598 Guildford court record gives an early written reference; the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries saw the game develop into organised adult competition; the 1744 Laws and the formation of MCC in 1787 helped codify it. Cricket reached India in the eighteenth century and was transformed by Indian communities over the nineteenth and twentieth centuries.

The two games should be studied together, but not collapsed into one origin story. They share the human pleasure of striking a moving object, judging distance and competing with others. Their histories show how local play can remain flexible while another game becomes institutional, codified and global. The relationship is meaningful even when direct ancestry cannot be proved.

At a glance: Gilli-Danda and Cricket

Feature	Gilli-Danda	Cricket
Projectile	Short tapered wooden gilli	Leather-covered ball with cork core
Striking implement	Long wooden danda	Flat-faced willow bat
Start of play	Gilli is flicked into the air, then struck	Bowler delivers ball toward batter
Scoring	Often distance, catches or local hit-count rules	Runs, boundaries, extras and wickets
Fielding	Flexible numbers and local roles	Eleven players per side in standard formal cricket
Rules	Regional and locally negotiated	Written Laws, governing bodies and match regulations
Historical record	Longstanding folk tradition; exact origin date uncertain	Documentary reference by 1598; formal laws in 1744
Institutional path	Primarily community and cultural preservation	Clubs, professional leagues, international governance

Visual explanation: Gilli-Danda

A simplified sequence is: (1) rest the tapered gilli on a notch or small base; (2) tap one end so it rises; (3) strike it while airborne; (4) fielders attempt a catch or return; (5) score using the local distance or hit-count convention. The exact sequence varies by region.

Visual explanation: Cricket

A standard delivery sequence is: (1) bowler runs in and delivers the ball; (2) batter defends the wicket or hits into the field; (3) batters may run between wickets; (4) fielders retrieve and return the ball; (5) innings continue until a dismissal or over limit. Formal cricket uses a defined pitch, wickets, boundaries and eleven players per side.

Historical paintings, photographs and visual archive

This register identifies historically useful images and their institutional records. Some records provide downloadable or open-access images; others may have reproduction restrictions. Always check the holding institution’s rights statement before publishing an image. No undated internet repost should be labelled “the oldest picture.”

Benjamin West, The Cricketers (1763)

Oil painting showing cricket among elite young men; National Portrait Gallery record.

https://npg.si.edu/object/npg_UK990702

Thomas Rowlandson, Rural Sports or a Cricket Match Extraordinary (1811)

Satirical cricket scene; National Gallery of Art identifies the image as public domain/open access.

https://www.nga.gov/artworks/31931-rural-sports-or-cricket-match-extraordinary

Members of the Calcutta Cricket Club (1859)

Photograph, India, 1859; National Army Museum collection record; out of copyright.

https://collection.nam.ac.uk/detail.php?acc=1984-07-9-63

A cricket match, Peshawar, circa 1896

Photograph, North-West Frontier; National Army Museum collection record; out of copyright.

https://collection.nam.ac.uk/detail.php?acc=2001-02-335-29

The Cricket Match between Sussex and Kent, at Brighton (published 1849)

Engraving based on a painting exhibited in 1846; Government Art Collection.

https://artcollection.dcms.gov.uk/artwork/7112/

Early cricket images in Australia (1842–1862)

State Library of New South Wales collection essay: John Rae watercolours, Thomas Lewis, S. T. Gill and early match photography.

https://www2.sl.nsw.gov.au/archive/discover_collections/society_art/cricket/early/viewer/early-images.html

Gilli-Danda / Viti-Dandu: contemporary documentation

Bharatiya Khel resource with regional names, rules and contemporary photographs; not an ancient image archive.

https://bharatiyakhel.iksindia.org/gilli-danda-viti-dandu/

Gilli-Danda: D'Source, IIT Bombay

Educational documentation of equipment, team roles and gameplay; useful for a modern rules illustration.

https://dsource.in/resource/indian-games/outdoor-games/gilli-danda

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Final historical assessment

The evidence supports two related but distinct histories. Gilli-Danda is a widely distributed folk game with deep cultural roots but no securely established invention date. Cricket has a documented English history by the late sixteenth century and developed through written laws, clubs, professional play and colonial networks. Their shared striking action makes comparison meaningful, but direct descent from Gilli-Danda to cricket has not been proven. The game’s history is richer when this uncertainty is made explicit rather than hidden.